

Latin root words

There are nearly 1,000 Latin root words used in English. Many of these words were introduced through French, which stems from Latin, after the Norman conquest of England in 1066.

Latin root	Meaning	Examples
aqua, aque	water	aquarium, aquatic, aqueduct
bi	two	biannual, bicycle, binary
cent	one hundred	centipede, century, percent
circum	round	circumference, circumnavigate, circumstance
form	shape	conform, formation, transform
jud	judgment	adjudicate, judge, judicial
liber, liver	free	liberation, liberty, deliver
liter	letter (alphabet)	literal, literate, literature
mater, matr	mother	maternity, matriarch, matronly
min	small	miniature, minimum, minority
pater, patr	father	paternal, patriotic, patron
quad	four	quadrant, quadratic, quadrilateral
terr	earth	extraterrestrial, terrain, territorial
tri	three	triangle, tricycle, trinity
uni	one	unicorn, uniform, universal

When words **share** the same root—such as **employ** in the words **employee, employer, and employment**—they are known as a **word family**.

Greek root words

There are hundreds of Greek roots used in English, especially relating to science. For example, *scope* in Greek means “to examine,” and is seen in many English words, such as *microscope* and *telescope*.

Greek roots	Meanings	Examples
aero	air	aerobics, aerosol, aerospace
bibl, biblio	book	Bible, bibliography, bibliophile
bio	life	antibiotic, biography, biology
cycl, cyclo	circle	bicycle, cyclical, cyclone
dec	ten	decade, decagon, decathlon
dem, demo	people	epidemic, democracy, demography
mega	great	megalomania, megaphone, megaton
pan	all	pandemic, panorama, pantheism
path	feeling	pathology, sympathy, telepathy
phobia	fearing	agoraphobia, arachnophobia, claustrophobia
phos, photo	light	phosphorus, photograph, photosynthesis
poly	many	polygon, polymath, polytechnic
psych	spirit	psychiatry, psychic, psychology
tele	far off	telekinetic, telephone, television
therm	heat	exothermic, thermal, thermometer



• There's **no easy way** to recognize whether a root is **Latin** or **Greek**. The best way to find out is to look the word up in a **dictionary**. The origin of the root will be mentioned in the entry.

GLOSSARY

Prefix A group of letters attached to the start of a word that can change the original word's meaning.

Suffix A group of letters attached to the end of a word that can change the original word's meaning.